

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Sales and Business Development English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

approval path

The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision.

buying committee

The people who influence or approve an organization's purchase decision.

buying process

The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

champion

A contact inside a customer organization who actively supports a proposed solution.

channel partner

An organization that helps market, sell, deliver, or support another organization's offering.

close date

The expected date on which a sales transaction will be completed.

commercial term

A business condition of an agreement, such as price, quantity, or payment timing.

commit

A sales forecast category indicating an expected close under the organization's defined criteria.

competitor

An organization offering an alternative that serves similar customer needs.

CRM

Customer relationship management: processes and systems used to manage customer information and interactions.

differentiator

A characteristic that meaningfully distinguishes an offering from alternatives.

discount

A reduction from a stated or usual price.

discovery

The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information.

economic buyer

The person with authority over the budget or financial approval for a purchase.

enablement

Resources and preparation that help a team perform a role effectively.

exclusivity

An arrangement limiting specified rights or activities to one party for an agreed scope.

forecast category

A defined label indicating the expected likelihood or stage of a sales opportunity.

indemnity

A contractual obligation to compensate for specified losses, subject to its terms and applicable law.

liability

Legal responsibility or an obligation; in accounting, an amount or duty owed.

margin

The difference or allowance between values; in business, a measure of profitability.

objection

A stated concern or reason for not accepting a proposal.

pain point

A specific difficulty experienced by a customer or user.

pipeline

A sequence of stages through which data, work, or sales opportunities move.

procurement

The process of sourcing, evaluating, and obtaining goods or services.

qualification

Documented demonstration that an item, process, or person meets defined requirements for a purpose.

redline

A version of a document showing proposed additions, deletions, or changes.

slippage

Movement of an expected completion or sales close date to a later time.

stakeholder

Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

success metric

A defined quantitative indicator tied to an intended outcome.

total cost

The combined costs included in a defined comparison, with assumptions stated.

use case

A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

value proposition

A clear explanation of the relevant benefit an offering provides to a particular customer.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Discovery and Qualification

A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

A sales slide lists product features, but the prospect wants to reduce time spent preparing monthly reports.

The relevant question is how the product supports your reporting workflow. I'll connect the demonstration to that task and show what would need to be tested before we claim a time saving.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

A prospect says a competitor is cheaper, but the quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

Could we compare the same scope and support assumptions? The quoted prices cover different packages. That will help us discuss total cost and fit without dismissing the other option.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

A customer requests a 15% discount. The salesperson can discuss options but does not have authority to approve that reduction.

I can take the request through our approval process. Could we clarify the scope and commercial terms you are proposing? I do not want to promise a discount before it is authorized.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Enterprise Buying Committees

A contact is enthusiastic about a proposal but has not explained who controls the budget or approves the purchase.

Who else needs to evaluate the proposal, and how is the budget approved? I'd like to understand the decision process so we can provide the right information to each participant.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Negotiation and Contract Redlines

A customer returns contract wording on liability and asks the salesperson to accept it immediately.

I'll send the proposed wording to the appropriate legal and commercial reviewers. Could you explain the business concern behind the change so they can assess it in context?

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Partnerships and Channel Development

A potential channel partner requests exclusivity but has not specified territory, activities, or expected contribution.

Could we define the territory, responsibilities, and expected contribution first? Those details are necessary for the team to evaluate whether an exclusive arrangement would make sense.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

A deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not started and the customer has given no confirmed date.

The current close date is an assumption. Procurement has not started, and the customer has not confirmed timing. I'll update the forecast explanation and identify the next evidence needed.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Sales and Business Development English

Professional audience: account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Discovery and Qualification

Original fictional case: A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: discovery: The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information. / qualification: Documented demonstration that an item, process, or person meets defined requirements for a purpose. / pain point: A specific difficulty experienced by a customer or user. / buying process: The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level